Chapter LV

The Scotchman

AND now our readers must leave the *Standard* to sail peaceably, not toward London, where D'Artagnan and Porthos believed they were going, but to Durham, whither Mordaunt had been ordered to repair by the letter he had received during his sojourn at Boulogne, and accompany us to the royalist camp, on this side of the Tyne, near Newcastle.

There, placed between two rivers on the borders of Scotland, but still on English soil, the tents of a little army extended. It was midnight. Some Highlanders were listlessly keeping watch. The moon, which was partially obscured by heavy clouds, now and then lit up the muskets of the sentinels, or silvered the walls, the roofs, and the spires of the town that Charles I had just surrendered to the parliamentary troops, whilst Oxford and Newark still held out for him in the hopes of coming to some arrangement.

At one of the extremities of the camp, near an immense tent, in which the Scottish officers were holding a kind of council, presided over by Lord Leven, their commander, a man attired as a cavalier lay sleeping on the turf, his right hand extended over his sword.

About fifty paces off, another man, also apparelled as a cavalier, was talking to a Scotch sentinel, and, though a foreigner, he seemed to understand without much difficulty the answers given in the broad Perthshire dialect.

As the town clock of Newcastle struck one the sleeper awoke, and with all the gestures of a man rousing himself out of deep sleep he looked attentively about him; perceiving that he was alone he rose and making a little circuit passed close to the cavalier who was speaking to the sentinel. The former had

no doubt finished his questions, for a moment later he said good-night and carelessly followed the same path taken by the first cavalier.

In the shadow of a tent the former was awaiting him.

'Well, my dear friend?' said he, in as pure French as has ever been uttered between Rouen and Tours.

'Well, my friend, there is not a moment to lose; we must let the king know immediately.'

'Why, what is the matter?'

'It would take too long to tell you, besides, you will hear it all directly and the least word dropped here might ruin all. We must go and find Lord Winter.'

They both set off to the other end of the camp, but as it did not cover more than a surface of five hundred feet they quickly arrived at the tent they were looking for.

'Tony, is your master sleeping?' said one of the two cavaliers to a servant who was lying in the outer compartment, which served as a kind of ante-room.

'No, monsieur le comte,' answered the servant, 'I think not; or at least he has not long been so, for he was pacing up and down for more than two hours after he left the king, and the sound of his footsteps has only ceased during the last ten minutes. However, you may look and see,' added the lackey, raising the curtained entrance of the tent.

Lord Winter was seated near an aperture, arranged as a window to let in the night air, his eyes mechanically following the course of the moon, intermittently veiled, as we before observed, by heavy clouds. The two friends approached Winter, who, with his head on his hands, was gazing at the heavens; he did not hear them enter and remained in the same attitude till he felt a hand upon his shoulder.

He turned around, recognised Athos and Aramis and held out his hand to them.

'Have you observed,' said he to them, 'what a blood-red colour the moon has to-night?'

'No,' replied Athos; 'I thought it looked much the same as usual.'

'Look, again, chevalier,' returned Lord Winter.

'I must own,' said Aramis, 'I am like the Comte de la Fère—I can see nothing remarkable about it.'

There they found a brig ready to set sail, upon the deck of which they recognised Mordaunt walking up and down impatiently.

'It is singular,' said D'Artagnan, whilst the boat was taking them to the Standard, 'it is astonishing how that young man resembles some one I must have known, but who it was I cannot yet remember.'

A few minutes later they were on board, but the embarkation of the horses was a longer matter than that of the men, and it was eight o'clock before they raised anchor.

The young man stamped impatiently and ordered all sail to be spread.

Porthos, completely used up by three nights without sleep and a journey of seventy leagues on horseback, retired to his cabin and went to sleep.

D'Artagnan, overcoming his repugnance to Mordaunt, walked with him upon the deck and invented a hundred stories to make him talk.

Mousqueton was seasick.

'Come, come, gentlemen,' said Mordaunt, impatiently, 'let us depart.'

'What!' exclaimed Porthos 'without supper? Cannot Monsieur Cromwell wait a little?'

'Yes, but I?' said Mordaunt.

'Well, you,' said Porthos, 'what then?'

'I cannot wait.'

'Oh! as to you, that is not my concern, and I shall sup either with or without your permission.'

The young man's eyes kindled in secret, but he restrained himself.

'Monsieur,' said D'Artagnan, 'you must excuse famished travellers. Besides, our supper can't delay you much. We will hasten on to the inn; you will meanwhile proceed on foot to the harbour. We will take a bite and shall be there as soon as you are.'

'Just as you please, gentlemen, provided we set sail,' he said.

'The name of your ship?' inquired D'Artagnan.

'The Standard.'

'Very well; in half an hour we shall be on board.'

And the friends, spurring on their horses, rode to the hotel, the 'Arms of England.'

'What do you say of that young man?' asked D'Artagnan, as they hurried along.

'I say that he doesn't suit me at all,' said Porthos, 'and that I feel a strong itching to follow Aramis's advice.'

'By no means, my dear Porthos; that man is a messenger of General Cromwell; it would insure for us a poor reception, I imagine, should it be announced to him that we had twisted the neck of his confidant.'

'Nevertheless,' said Porthos, 'I have always noticed that Aramis gives good advice.'

'Listen,' returned D'Artagnan, 'when our embassy is finished— '

'Well?'

'If it brings us back to France— '

'Well?'

'Well, we shall see.'

At that moment the two friends reached the hotel, 'Arms of England,' where they supped with hearty appetite and then at once proceeded to the port.

'My lord,' said Athos, 'in a position so precarious as ours we must examine the earth and not the heavens. Have you studied our Scotch troops and have you confidence in them?'

'The Scotch?' inquired Winter. 'What Scotch?'

'Ours, egad!' exclaimed Athos. 'Those in whom the king has confided—Lord Leven's Highlanders.'

'No,' said Winter, then he paused; 'but tell me, can you not perceive the russet tint which marks the heavens?'

'Not the least in the world,' said Aramis and Athos at once.

'Tell me,' continued Winter, always possessed by the same idea, 'is there not a tradition in France that Henry IV, the evening before the day he was assassinated, when he was playing at chess with M. de Bassompiere, saw clots of blood upon the chessboard?'

'Yes,' said Athos, 'and the maréchal has often told me so himself.'

'Then it was so,' murmured Winter, 'and the next day Henry IV was killed.'

'But what has this vision of Henry IV to do with you, my lord?' inquired Aramis.

'Nothing; and indeed I am mad to trouble you with such things, when your coming to my tent at such an hour announces that you are the bearers of important news.'

'Yes, my lord,' said Athos, 'I wish to speak to the king.'

'To the king! but the king is asleep.'

'I have something important to reveal to him.'

'Can it not be put off till to-morrow?'

'He must know it this moment, and perhaps it is already too late.'

'Come, then,' said Lord Winter.

Lord Winter's tent was pitched by the side of the royal marquee, a kind of corridor communicating between the two. This corridor was guarded, not by a sentinel, but by a confidential servant, through whom, in case of urgency, Charles could communicate instantly with his faithful subject.

'These gentlemen are with me,' said Winter.

The lackey bowed and let them pass. As he had said, on a camp bed, dressed in his black doublet, booted, unbelted, with his felt hat beside him, lay the king, overcome by sleep and fatigue. They advanced, and Athos, who was the first to enter, gazed a moment in silence on that pale and noble face, framed

in its long and now untidy, matted hair, the blue veins showing through the transparent temples, his eyes seemingly swollen by tears.

Athos sighed deeply; the sigh woke the king, so lightly did he sleep.

He opened his eyes.

'Ah!' said he, raising himself on his elbow, 'is it you, Comte de la Fère?'

'Yes, sire,' replied Athos.

'You watch while I sleep and you have come to bring me some news?'

'Alas, sire,' answered Athos, 'your majesty has guessed aright.'

'It is bad news?'

'Yes, sire.'

'Never mind; the messenger is welcome. You never come to me without conferring pleasure. You whose devotion recognises neither country nor misfortune, you who are sent to me by Henrietta; whatever news you bring, speak out.'

'Sire, Cromwell has arrived this night at Newcastle.'

'Ah!' exclaimed the king, 'to fight?'

'No, sire, but to buy your majesty.'

'What did you say?'

'I said, sire, that four hundred thousand pounds are owing to the Scottish army.'

'For unpaid wages; yes, I know it. For the last year my faithful Highlanders have fought for honour alone.'

Athos smiled.

'Well, sir, though honour is a fine thing, they are tired of fighting for it, and to-night they have sold you for two hundred thousand pounds—that is to say, for half what is owing them.'

'Impossible!' cried the king, 'the Scotch sell their king for two hundred thousand pounds! And who is the Judas who has concluded this infamous bargain?'

'Lord Leven.'

'Are you certain of it, sir?'

'I heard it with my own ears.'

The king sighed deeply, as if his heart would break, and then buried his face in his hands.

At ten steps from the place where they halted was a young man in black, who seemed waiting for some one, and who, from the moment he saw them enter the town, never took his eyes off them.

D'Artagnan approached him, and seeing him stare so fixedly, said:

'Well, friend! I don't like people to quiz me!'

'Sir,' said the young man, 'do you not come from Paris, if you please?'

D'Artagnan thought it was some gossip who wanted news from the capital.

'Yes, sir,' he said, in a softened tone.

'Are you not going to put up at the "Arms of England"?'

'Yes, sir.'

'Are you not charged with a mission from his eminence, Cardinal Mazarin?'

'Yes, sir.'

'In that case, I am the man you have to do with. I am M. Mordaunt.'

'Ah!' thought D'Artagnan, 'the man I am warned against by Athos.'

'Ah!' thought Porthos, 'the man Aramis wants me to strangle.'

They both looked searchingly at the young man, who misunderstood the meaning of that inquisition.

'Do you doubt my word?' he said. 'In that case I can give you proofs.'

'No, sir,' said D'Artagnan; 'and we place ourselves at your orders.'

'Well, gentlemen,' resumed Mordaunt, 'we must set out without delay, to-day is the last day granted me by the cardinal. My ship is ready, and had you not come I must have set off without you, for General Cromwell expects my return impatiently.'

'So!' thought the lieutenant, ''tis to General Cromwell that our dispatches are addressed.'

'Have you no letter for him?' asked the young man.

'I have one, the seal of which I am not to break till I reach London; but since you tell me to whom it is addressed, 'tis useless to wait till then.'

D'Artagnan tore open the envelope of the letter. It was directed to 'Monsieur Oliver Cromwell, General of the Army of the English Nation.'

'Ah!' said D'Artagnan; 'a singular commission.'

'Who is this Monsieur Oliver Cromwell?' inquired Porthos.

'Formerly a brewer,' replied the Gascon.

'Perhaps Mazarin wishes to make a speculation in beer, as we did in straw,' said Porthos.

'Oh, sir! oh!'

'And, more especially, a notorious coward.'

'Oh, oh! sir! you really vilify me!' cried Olivain.

'The deuce!' cried D'Artagnan. 'Pray learn, Monsieur Olivain, that people like us are not to be served by cowards. Rob your master, eat his sweetmeats, and drink his wine; but, by Jove! don't be a coward, or I shall cut off your ears. Look at Monsieur Mouston, see the honourable wounds he has received, observe how his habitual valour has given dignity to his countenance.'

Mousqueton was in the third heaven and would have embraced D'Artagnan had he dared; meanwhile he resolved to sacrifice his life for him on the next occasion that presented itself.

'Send away that fellow, Raoul,' said the Gascon; 'for if he's a coward he will disgrace thee some day.'

'Monsieur says I am coward,' cried Olivain, 'because he wanted the other day to fight a cornet in Grammont's regiment and I refused to accompany him.'

'Monsieur Olivain, a lackey ought never to disobey,' said D'Artagnan, sternly; then taking him aside, he whispered to him: 'Thou hast done right; thy master was in the wrong; here's a crown for thee, but should he ever be insulted and thou dost not let thyself be cut in quarters for him, I will cut out thy tongue. Remember that.'

Olivain bowed and slipped the crown into his pocket.

'And now, Raoul,' said the Gascon, 'Monsieur du Vallon and I are going away as ambassadors, where, I know not; but should you want anything, write to Madame Turquaine, at La Chevrette, Rue Tiquetonne and draw upon her purse as on a banker—with economy; for it is not so well filled as that of Monsieur d'Emery.'

And having, meantime, embraced his ward, he passed him into the robust arms of Porthos, who lifted him up from the ground and held him a moment suspended near the noble heart of the formidable giant.

'Come,' said D'Artagnan, 'let us go.'

And they set out for Boulogne, where toward evening they arrived, their horses flecked with foam and dark with perspiration.

'Oh! the Scotch,' he exclaimed, 'the Scotch I called "my faithful," to whom I trusted myself when I could have fled to Oxford! the Scotch, my brothers! But are you well assured, sir?'

'Lying behind the tent of Lord Leven, I raised it and saw all, heard all!'

'And when is this to be consummated?'

'To-day—this morning; so your majesty must perceive there is no time to lose!'

'To do what? since you say I am sold.'

'To cross the Tyne, reach Scotland and rejoin Lord Montrose, who will not sell you.'

'And what shall I do in Scotland? A war of partisans, unworthy of a king.'

'The example of Robert Bruce will absolve you, sire.'

'No, no! I have fought too long; they have sold me, they shall give me up, and the eternal shame of treble treason shall fall on their heads.'

'Sire,' said Athos, 'perhaps a king should act thus, but not a husband and a father. I have come in the name of your wife and daughter and of the children you have still in London, and I say to you, "Live, sire,"—it is the will of Heaven.'

The king raised himself, buckled on his belt, and passing his handkerchief over his moist forehead, said:

'Well, what is to be done?'

'Sire, have you in the army one regiment on which you can implicitly rely?'

'Winter,' said the king, 'do you believe in the fidelity of yours?'

'Sire, they are but men, and men are become both weak and wicked. I will not answer for them. I would confide my life to them, but I should hesitate ere I trusted them with your majesty's.'

'Well!' said Athos, 'since you have not a regiment, we are three devoted men. It is enough. Let your majesty mount on horseback and place yourself in the midst of us; we will cross the Tyne, reach Scotland, and you will be saved.'

'Is this your counsel also, Winter?' inquired the king.

'Yes, sire.'

'And yours, Monsieur d'Herblay?'

'Yes, sire.'

'As you wish, then. Winter, give the necessary orders.'

Winter then left the tent; in the meantime the king finished his toilet. The first rays of daybreak penetrated the aperture of the tent as Winter re-entered it.

'All is ready, sire,' said he.

'For us, also?' inquired Athos.

'Grimaud and Blaisois are holding your horses, ready saddled.'

'In that case,' exclaimed Athos, 'let us not lose an instant, but set off.'

'Come,' added the king.

'Sire,' said Aramis, 'will not your majesty acquaint some of your friends of this?'

'Friends!' answered Charles, sadly, 'I have but three—one of twenty years, who has never forgotten me, and two of a week's standing, whom I shall never forget. Come, gentlemen, come!'

The king quitted his tent and found his horse ready waiting for him. It was a chestnut that the king had ridden for three years and of which he was very fond.

The horse neighed with pleasure at seeing him.

'Ah!' said the king, 'I was unjust; here is a creature that loves me. You at least will be faithful to me, Arthur.'

The horse, as if it understood these words, bent its red nostrils toward the king's face, and parting his lips displayed all its teeth, as if with pleasure.

'Yes, yes,' said the king, caressing it with his hand, 'yes, my Arthur, thou art a fond and faithful creature.'

After this little scene Charles threw himself into the saddle, and turning to Athos, Aramis and Winter, said:

'Now, gentlemen, I am at your service.'

But Athos was standing with his eyes fixed on a black line which bordered the banks of the Tyne and seemed to extend double the length of the camp.

'What is that line?' cried Athos, whose vision was still rather obscured by the uncertain shades and demi-tints of daybreak. 'What is that line? I did not observe it yesterday.'

'It must be the fog rising from the river,' said the king.

'Sire, it is something more opaque than the fog.'

'Indeed!' said Winter, 'it appears to me like a bar of red colour.'

'Oh, yes, Monsieur Raoul!' said Mousqueton, 'the letter was very consoling. These gentlemen read it to me and I wept for joy.'

'But at any rate, you know where he is, Monsieur d'Artagnan?' asked Raoul, somewhat comforted.

'Ah! that's the thing!' replied the Gascon. 'Undoubtedly I know it, but it is a mystery.'

'Not to me, I hope?'

'No, not to you, so I am going to tell you where he is.'

Porthos devoured D'Artagnan with wondering eyes.

'Where the devil shall I say that he is, so that he cannot try to rejoin him?' thought D'Artagnan.

'Well, where is he, sir?' asked Raoul, in a soft and coaxing voice.

'He is at Constantinople.'

'Among the Turks!' exclaimed Raoul, alarmed. 'Good heavens! how can you tell me that?'

'Does that alarm you?' cried D'Artagnan. 'Pooh! what are the Turks to such men as the Comte de la Fère and the Abbé d'Herblay?'

'Ah, his friend is with him?' said Raoul. 'That comforts me a little.'

'Has he wit or not—this demon D'Artagnan?' said Porthos, astonished at his friend's deception.

'Now, sir,' said D'Artagnan, wishing to change the conversation, 'here are fifty pistoles that the count has sent you by the same courier. I suppose you have no more money and that they will be welcome.'

'I have still twenty pistoles, sir.'

'Well, take them; that makes seventy.'

'And if you wish for more,' said Porthos, putting his hand to his pocket—

'Thank you, sir,' replied Raoul, blushing; 'thank you a thousand times.'

At this moment Olivain appeared. 'Apropos,' said D'Artagnan, loud enough for the servant to hear him, 'are you satisfied with Olivain?'

'Yes, in some respects, tolerably well.'

Olivain pretended to have heard nothing and entered the tent.

'What fault do you find with the fellow?'

'He is a glutton.'

'Oh, sir!' cried Olivain, reappearing at this accusation.

'And a little bit of a thief.'

'Long live De Beaufort!' cried the guards, and they drew back respectfully to let the two friends pass. Once across the barriers these two knew neither fatigue nor fear. Their horses flew, and they never ceased speaking of Athos and Aramis.

The camp had entered Saint Omer; the friends made a little detour and went to the camp, and gave the army an exact account of the flight of the king and queen. They found Raoul near his tent, reclining on a truss of hay, of which his horse stole some mouthfuls; the young man's eyes were red and he seemed dejected. The Maréchal de Grammont and the Comte de Guiche had returned to Paris and he was quite lonely. And as soon as he saw the two cavaliers he ran to them with open arms.

'Oh, is it you, dear friends? Did you come here to fetch me? Will you take me away with you? Do you bring me tidings of my guardian?'

'Have you not received any?' said D'Artagnan to the youth.

'Alas! sir, no, and I do not know what has become of him; so that I am really so unhappy that I weep.'

In fact, tears rolled down his cheeks.

Porthos turned aside, in order not to show by his honest round face what was passing in his mind.

'Deuce take it!' cried D'Artagnan, more moved than he had been for a long time, 'don't despair, my friend, if you have not received any letters from the count, we have received one.'

'Oh, really!' cried Raoul.

'And a comforting one, too,' added D'Artagnan, seeing the delight that his intelligence gave the young man.

'Have you it?' asked Raoul

'Yes—that is, I had it,' repined the Gascon, making believe to find it. 'Wait, it ought to be there in my pocket; it speaks of his return, does it not, Porthos?'

All Gascon as he was, D'Artagnan could not bear alone the weight of that falsehood.

'Yes,' replied Porthos, coughing.

'Eh, give it to me!' said the young man.

'Eh! I read it a little while since. Can I have lost it? Ah! confound it! yes, my pocket has a hole in it.'

'It is the enemy, who have made a sortie from Newcastle and are surrounding us!' exclaimed Athos.

'The enemy!' cried the king.

'Yes, the enemy. It is too late. Stop a moment; does not that sunbeam yonder, just by the side of the town, glitter on the Ironsides?'

This was the name given the cuirassiers, whom Cromwell had made his body-guard.

'Ah!' said the king, 'we shall soon see whether my Highlanders have betrayed me or not.'

'What are you going to do?' exclaimed Athos.

'To give them the order to charge, and run down these miserable rebels.'

And the king, putting spurs to his horse, set off to the tent of Lord Leven.

'Follow him,' said Athos.

'Come!' exclaimed Aramis.

'Is the king wounded?' cried Lord Winter. 'I see spots of blood on the ground.' And he set off to follow the two friends.

He was stopped by Athos.

'Go and call out your regiment,' said he; 'I can foresee that we shall have need of it directly.'

Winter turned his horse and the two friends rode on. It had taken but two minutes for the king to reach the tent of the Scottish commander; he dismounted and entered.

The general was there, surrounded by the more prominent chiefs.

'The king!' they exclaimed, as all rose in bewilderment.

Charles was indeed in the midst of them, his hat on his head, his brows bent, striking his boot with his riding whip.

'Yes, gentlemen, the king in person, the king who has come to ask for some account of what has happened.'

'What is the matter, sire?' exclaimed Lord Leven.

'It is this, sir,' said the king, angrily, 'that General Cromwell has reached Newcastle; that you knew it and I was not informed of it; that the enemy have left the town and are now closing the passages of the Tyne against us; that our sentinels have seen this movement and I have been left unacquainted with it; that, by an infamous treaty you have sold me for two hundred thousand pounds to Parliament. Of this treaty, at least, I have been warned. This is the

'Yes, gentlemen, the king in person'

'If that is all, it is easily done,' said Porthos.

'On the contrary,' observed D'Artagnan, with a vexed look; 'it would be impossible.'

'How so?'

'It is precisely this Monsieur Mordaunt whom we are going to join at Boulogne and with whom we cross to England.'

'Well, suppose instead of joining this Monsieur Mordaunt we were to go and join our friends?' said Porthos, with a gesture fierce enough to have frightened an army.

'I did think of it, but this letter has neither date nor postmark.'

'True,' said Porthos. And he began to wander about the room like a man beside himself, gesticulating and half drawing his sword out of the scabbard.

As to D'Artagnan, he remained standing like a man in consternation, with the deepest affliction depicted on his face.

'Ah, this is not right; Athos insults us; he wishes to die alone; it is bad, bad, bad.'

Mousqueton, witnessing this despair, melted into tears in a corner of the room.

'Come,' said D'Artagnan, 'all this leads to nothing. Let us go on. We will embrace Raoul, and perhaps he will have news of Athos.'

'Stop—an idea!' cried Porthos; 'indeed, my dear D'Artagnan, I don't know how you manage, but you are always full of ideas; let us go and embrace Raoul.'

'Woe to that man who should happen to contradict my master at this moment,' said Mousqueton to himself; 'I wouldn't give a farthing for his life.'

They set out. On arriving at the Rue Saint Denis, the friends found a vast concourse of people. It was the Duc de Beaufort, who was coming from the Vendomois and whom the coadjutor was showing to the Parisians, intoxicated with joy. With the duke's aid they already considered themselves invincible.

The two friends turned off into a side street to avoid meeting the prince, and so reached the Saint Denis gate.

'Is it true,' said the guard to the two cavaliers, 'that the Duc de Beaufort has arrived in Paris?'

'Nothing more certain; and the best proof of it is,' said D'Artagnan, 'that he has dispatched us to meet the Duc de Vendôme, his father, who is coming in his turn.'

'I believe, by Heaven,' said D'Artagnan, 'that I shall embrace him, since he's upon our road; and if he is so unfortunate as to lose our dear Athos, from that very day he becomes my son.'

'And I,' said Porthos, 'shall make him my sole heir.'

'Let us see, what more does Athos say?'

> Should you meet on your journey a certain Monsieur Mordaunt, distrust him, in a letter I cannot say more.

'Monsieur Mordaunt!' exclaimed the Gascon, surprised.

'Monsieur Mordaunt! 'tis well,' said Porthos, 'we shall remember that; but see, there is a postscript from Aramis.'

'So there is,' said D'Artagnan, and he read:

> We conceal the place where we are, dear friends, knowing your brotherly affection and that you would come and die with us were we to reveal it.

'Confound it,' interrupted Porthos, with an explosion of passion which sent Mousqueton to the other end of the room; 'are they in danger of dying?'

D'Artagnan continued:

> Athos bequeaths to you Raoul, and I bequeath to you my revenge. If by any good luck you lay your hand on a certain man named Mordaunt, tell Porthos to take him into a corner and to wring his neck. I dare not say more in a letter.
>
> ARAMIS.

matter, gentlemen; answer and exculpate yourselves, for I stand here to accuse you.'

'Sire,' said Lord Leven, with hesitation, 'sire, your majesty has been deceived by false reports.'

'My own eyes have seen the enemy extend itself between myself and Scotland; and I can almost say that with my own ears I have heard the clauses of the treaty debated.'

The Scotch chieftains looked at each other in their turn with frowning brows.

'Sire,' murmured Lord Leven, crushed by shame, 'sire, we are ready to give you every proof of our fidelity.'

'I ask but one,' said the king; 'put the army in battle array and face the enemy.'

'That cannot be, sire,' said the earl.

'How, cannot be? What hinders it?' exclaimed the king.

'Your majesty is well aware that there is a truce between us and the English army.'

'And if there is a truce the English army has broken it by quitting the town, contrary to the agreement which kept it there. Now, I tell you, you must pass with me through this army across to Scotland, and if you refuse you may choose betwixt two names, which the contempt of all honest men will brand you with—you are either cowards or traitors!'

The eyes of the Scotch flashed fire; and, as often happens on such occasions, from shame they passed to effrontery and two heads of clans advanced upon the king.

'Yes,' said they, 'we have promised to deliver Scotland and England from him who for the last five-and-twenty years has sucked the blood and gold of Scotland and England. We have promised and we will keep our promise. Charles Stuart, you are our prisoner.'

And both extended their hands as if to seize the king, but before they could touch him with the tips of their fingers, both had fallen, one dead, the other stunned.

Aramis had passed his sword through the body of the first and Athos had knocked down the other with the butt end of his pistol.

Then, as Lord Leven and the other chieftains recoiled before this unexpected rescue, which seemed to come from Heaven for the prince they already thought was their prisoner, Athos and Aramis dragged the king from the perjured assembly into which he had so imprudently ventured, and throwing themselves on horseback all three returned at full gallop to the royal tent.

On their road they perceived Lord Winter marching at the head of his regiment. The king motioned him to accompany them.

Five minutes afterward he entered the hotel of La Chevrette, where pretty Madeleine, the hostess, came to him.

'My dear Mistress Turquaine,' said the Gascon, 'if you happen to have any money, lock it up quickly; if you happen to have any jewels, hide them directly; if you happen to have any debtors, make them pay you, or any creditors, don't pay them.'

'Why, prithee?' asked Madeleine.

'Because Paris is going to be reduced to dust and ashes like Babylon, of which you have no doubt heard tell.'

'And are you going to leave me at such a time?'

'This very instant.'

'And where are you going?'

'Ah, if you could tell me that, you would be doing me a service.'

'Ah, me! ah, me!'

'Have you any letters for me?' inquired D'Artagnan, wishing to signify to the hostess that her lamentations were superfluous and that therefore she had better spare him demonstrations of her grief.

'There's one just arrived,' and she handed the letter to D'Artagnan.

'From Athos!' cried D'Artagnan, recognizing the handwriting.

'Ah!' said Porthos, 'let us hear what he says.'

D'Artagnan opened the letter and read as follows:

> Dear D'Artagnan, dear Du Vallon, my good friends, perhaps this may be the last time that you will ever hear from me. Aramis and I are very unhappy; but God, our courage, and the remembrance of our friendship sustain us. Think often of Raoul. I intrust to you certain papers which are at Blois; and in two months and a half, if you do not hear of us, take possession of them.
>
> Embrace, with all your heart, the vicomte, for your devoted, friend,
>
> Athos.